

In this video, I'm going to share my journey to 100,000 subscribers from zero, how much YouTube paid me along the way, and how long it took. Why? Because you asked. Also, I've got nothing to hide. And I remember what it was like when I was starting out. I was looking for any information I could find, how long this journey takes, and how long it's going to take to actually start making some real money and go full-time.

2020 is actually when this journey started because that's the year that I started doing research and started to look into doing YouTube. I was a freelance video editor at the time working through Fiverr and making good money at that. I was making a living doing that and having fun but it was busy. I was looking at YouTube as being possibly something to do in my next chapter, right? I loved the idea of making my own videos instead of editing videos for other people.

So, I started to research. I started to look into cameras, how they work, how to film myself, microphones and all the things. So, I guess the last half of 2020 is when I was... well, I guess that was COVID time, right? So, that's when I was doing my research and trying to figure out how it all works. Studying up on YouTube and watching a lot of videos, being a consumer.

By the end of the year, I hadn't made any videos. But I had three subscribers, my two kids and my nephew, because I told them, "Hey, I'm going to be a YouTuber. You should subscribe." So that was 2020.

2021, that's when the creator journey began. So I made my first video. In fact, my first month, I made nine videos January 2021. I was a little disappointed at the end of that though because it only gained me three subscribers by the end of that month. So I gave it up. So yeah, I gave it up for many months. I made one more video that year. So for the total for 2021, I made 10 videos, but I did grow to 396 subscribers, but only 720 watch hours. So wasn't even close to being monetized.

I was intrigued by how my subscriber numbers grew even though I wasn't really posting videos for most of that year. So that was lesson learned there.

In 2022, I jumped back up on the horse and started creating videos again. I made 17 that year, so almost one and a half per month. And I grew to 1,800 subscribers by the end of that year, and the watch hours were over 3,500 hours. So that's great. I was happy with that. I wasn't being very consistent. I kind of made videos in spurts and then took many months off between.

That's one of the things you need to do to get monetized. And I think I remember at the time I was thinking well 1,000 subscribers, the 4,000 watch hours must be right around the corner. But that lagged a little bit. I was not there yet by the end of the year. But it looked like it might be coming. So yeah, pretty happy with that year. Grand total made that year also zero.

2023 was a tough year. That's the year I think I moved. And yeah, I wasn't able to keep up the pace. When you're starting off as a creator, as many of you may know, there's a lot to learn. And if you don't see constant growth, you get discouraged and it's so easy to take breaks. And I can't stress enough how important it is to stay consistent with your posting.

The more consistent you can be, the more you'll be rewarded with growth, with subscribers, views, and so on. So that year, 2023, I only made six videos the whole year. The subscriber count kept growing though. Now I've kind of developed a library of videos. So some of the old videos were still getting views and subscribers.

Subscribers grew to over 2600 by the end of 2023. But my watch hours fell to 2700 from 3,500 at the end of the previous year. This is a good time for me to remind you that the 4,000 watch hours that you need, that's 4,000 watch hours within your last 365 days. So it's a moving target. It's a moving window. So once it's been a year since you've had a video that got you a bunch of watch hours, those watch hours disappear. They fall off the back end.

So that year was a setback. By the end of that year, I was thinking, okay, subscribers are growing. That's kind of cool to see that that actually happens even when you're not being consistent. I mean, six videos for the whole year. That's one every two months. But I think most of them I made in just a month or two. I took most of the year off. So by the end of that year also zero dollars earned.

2024 was a huge year for me. And I want to break this one up into two sections. The first half and the second half. Because they are two completely different stories.

By this time I'm still working full-time as a freelancer through Fiverr. That is how I'm making my income. So up until this point I've been doing YouTube on the side and in my spare time. That's a reason why I wasn't able to make that many videos at this point early in 2024.

By that time I realized how this works. Not how everything works, but I at least understood that growth can happen if I can stay consistent. So I got some systems in place that allowed me to make a lot of videos quickly.

How-to type videos, search-based videos, and I doubled down on live streaming. I had been doing some live streaming the year before and I enjoyed it. So that was part of my plan as well.

So the first half of 2024, I made 45 videos. That's a lot of videos. And my subscriber count grew to 3839 subscribers. And that's great. At this point, the subscribers don't matter as much. I've already passed the thousand mark. It's the watch hours that I needed.

But by the end of the first half of 2024, my watch hours were 6,400. So I had just gotten monetized. In fact, it was late May of 2024 that I got monetized.

Mostly because I was making three videos a week. I was showing up all the time. I was going live every week. And I started the conversation with my viewers. They were asking me to make certain videos. I was making them. We were talking about them in the lives.

It was a busy time, but it was a fun time. Really busy because again, I was still editing videos for other people through my freelance business.

So I got monetized and in that first half I made \$259 from YouTube. First YouTube check arrived about a month later.

My first full monetized month I think was around \$230 is what I made that first month. So off to the races.

If I thought things were getting real in the first half of 2024, the second half of the year blew it away. In this second half, I made 54 videos. So a little bit more than the first half, but that's not the bulk of the story.

I made a video early in July of that year that took off. It far outpaced my subscriber growth and brought in hundreds of thousands of views. And what ended up happening from that is my subscriber growth grew by like 20,000 subscribers in the matter of a month or two.

Things really started to take off. I made a bunch of money that month for July. So I got that in August. \$1,600 I believe it was for one month. That was my second YouTube paycheck.

So now I'm thinking, "Holy cow, \$230 I made in June and then 1,600 in July." This is where it's important for me to point out that when you have a viral video like that, that does not mean everything levels up and stays up.

Yes, July and even August were phenomenal months. July in terms of earnings, the subscribers kept growing all through the rest of that year. But the earnings did not.

The earnings were 1,600 that first month, but they were down... I believe it was less than \$600 in August and maybe \$800 in the next month, July, August, September. Anyways, I'll put that on screen.

But my point is even if your subscriber numbers are growing, that doesn't mean your earnings are growing. And this is a huge lesson that you don't understand until you go through it.

A lot of people will ask me, "Oh, well, how much money do you make from YouTube with, you know, 100,000 subscribers, with 50,000 subscribers," and they try to do a correlation. But it just does not work that way.

You get subscribers when you have a good video that a lot of people like, and they decide they want to watch more of you and they want to be notified, so they'll subscribe. But it's the actual views that you get that have more to do with how much money YouTube will pay you for your videos.

So by the end of 2024, I was up to almost 31,000 subscribers. Fantastic year. I was at 3,800 the year before. And the watch hours is now no longer an issue, 87,000.

And at the end of the year, for all of 2024, I had earned just over \$6,200. So a great year. That year, 2024, is the year I became a full-time YouTuber.

I'm going to say right around the time I got monetized, I was working YouTube pretty much full-time. Maybe the odd freelance job still on the go at that point, but it was right around then, halfway through the year, that I was doing YouTube full-time, not earning a full-time income, because I had just started earning money from YouTube.

But the second half of that year, I continued to work it full-time and I've been working it full-time ever since.

Half of that year is I did start earning a full-time income, not just from YouTube. And this is what I want to stress. Sometimes it's difficult to make a full-time... Most times it's difficult to make a full-time income just from YouTube AdSense alone.

More often than not, people who are successful on YouTube are that way because they leverage YouTube into other businesses, into other streams of revenue. And that's what I did. I started creating courses and I started offering coaching. And I set up affiliate sales through Amazon.

So there was a bunch of things that I did and it created a bunch of other revenue streams. And if you want to know more about that kind of stuff, let me know. I know I haven't really talked about that kind of stuff on this channel. It's been all about YouTube, but anybody who wants to know about that stuff, let me know and I can make videos about it.

But the bottom line was by the end of 2024, I was making a full-time income with the help of YouTube, not entirely from YouTube.

2025 was another great year of growth. I made 91 videos throughout the year. 63 live streams, so more than a live stream every week. I live streamed at least once a week, but I did a few extra ones as well.

And my subscriber count grew from just over 30,000 to over 93,000. So huge year of growth. As far as watch hours, 286,000 watch hours in that year. So way more than you need. Again, that's not an issue anymore.

And the amount I earned from YouTube AdSense was just over \$28,000 for the year 2025.

2026 is the year that I finally hit 100,000 subscribers. It was about two months ago, February 7th, and I've got some lessons I want to share with you as well, and I thought it'd be easier to do it here from my office.

The first lesson is that monthly revenue can vary wildly. It's not consistent at all, and I'll show you this here. You can see that throughout 2025 I earned anywhere from \$1,500 to

\$3,500 a month.

It's been a year since that month when I made \$3,500. And so far this year in 2026, 2400, 800, 700. So it's lower than it was a year ago, even though my subscriber count is over 100,000 whereas a year ago it was around 40 to 50,000.

Even going right back to when I had that first viral video and earned \$1,600 in July of 2024, I only had 16,000 subscribers then. So there's really no correlation between the number of subscribers that you have and the amount that you make per month.

The second lesson is that if you do get a video to go viral, and you get a spike in views and if you're monetized at the time, earnings, that's almost always followed by a dip. You can see in my case, revenues came way down, down to less than a third two months later after that big spike in 2024. Then it slowly started to come back up.

But you got to be careful about the unrealistic expectations that you might have after having a video go viral.

The third lesson is that you can make a full-time income from your YouTube channel by leveraging your channel. So I'm not talking about just earnings from AdSense, and that's what I talked about in this video, but other ways to earn money by selling digital products, by becoming an affiliate for software companies, or on Amazon for any products that people can buy on Amazon.

You can become an affiliate and earn income that way. You could become a consultant and help other people with their YouTube channels or with their businesses. You can become a coach like I did. So there's so many other things that you could do that you can use your YouTube channel to help drive traffic to your business.

I hope you found this helpful. My name is Rob and if you need help with anything, feel free to let me know. You can let me know in the comments below. Or if you have any questions about any of this, let me know that, too. And that said, I'll see you in the next video. All right, take care.